

THREAT



PAWAN BHAWAR



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TERROR RISING: The scene after the bomb blasts in Malegaon on September 29

bunch of RSS *pracharaks* and full-timers, who had broken away from the Sangh following ideological disputes. It shot to prominence earlier this year following the riots at Indore in July. The organisation protested the cases registered against 13 Hindus in connection with the riots, alleging that local factional politics in the BJP was behind the "bogus cases". Abhinav Bharat, with a base in several states, was headed by Himani Savarkar, the daughter of Nathuram Godse's elder brother and daughter-in-law of Vinayak Damodar, "Veer" Savarkar's brother.

Caught by surprise, intelligence agencies are now trying to piece together the new terror profiles. An Intelligence Bureau

(IB) official admitted that they were getting reports from their local units about the emergence of the new Sadhvi. "She was often compared to Uma Bharati in her heyday. She was known to make inflammatory speeches. However, neither the local IB personnel nor the police imagined that she would get involved in organised acts of terror," he said.

But now, with women emerging as key players in inciting communal passions, the intelligence agencies have also turned their attention towards Durga Vahini, the women's wing of the militant Bajrang Dal. The VHP raised Durga Vahini in 1991. Headed by firebrand Sadhvi Ritambhara when the Ayodhya

movement was at its peak, it was at the forefront of the movement in its final, decisive phase and also took the lead of the squad that demolished the controversial Babri structure on December 6, 1992. Vahini members had reportedly played an active role in the Gujarat riots.

To intelligence agencies, one thing has increasingly become clear: these organisations have been openly getting involved in violence, whether it was Godhra, Amarnath or Kandhamal, or further in the past, the 1992 Mumbai riots. The organisations, their activities and leaders are now under the scanner. More worrying is the involvement of serving and former army personnel in the training